



Allergens and knowing what is in your food or drink

K

Know

Useful things to know

- Knowing and being able to tell customers what's in your food will allow them to make informed choices. This is especially important for people with food allergies. Food allergies can result in life-threatening reactions that can occur within minutes of eating the food.
- If you are making foods on behalf of other businesses (for example a contract manufacturer) you're responsible for ensuring any ingredients used in your business are safe and suitable.
- The Australia New Zealand Food Standards Code ([the Code](#)) contains rules you may need to meet. The Code is found here: www.foodstandards.gov.au/food-standards-code/legislation.
- The Code includes rules about:
 - which foods or ingredients are allergens,
 - which additives, preservatives and processing aids can be (or must be) used with particular foods,
 - ingredients that can't be used in food – or need to be approved before they are used,
 - composition rules that only apply to some foods, (such as beer, chocolate, fruit juice, edible oils and wine),
 - anything that must be added to a particular food (for example, fortification of bread flour with folic acid or using iodised salt in bread).



- You can check the Code or ask your consultant, verifier or registration authority for more information.
- If you think a food isn't labelled correctly (for example missing allergen information), check with your supplier before selling it.



- Wine: Not all food additives or ingredients listed in the Code can be used in all overseas markets. If you are exporting wine you need to check that anything you are using is permitted in wine for that market and/or is added at the right time. Follow the ['Meeting the export requirements \(wine only\)'](#) [orange] card.



- Importers: You must know the allergen labelling rules in New Zealand. You must get accurate and reliable ingredient information from your overseas suppliers about the foods you import so allergens can be declared.



- Importers: Not all food additives or ingredients used overseas are allowed to be used in food and drink sold in New Zealand. You will need to check that the food or drink contains approved food additives and ingredients listed in the Code for any food you import.

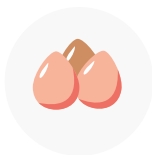


- Importers: Food may be imported with labels that don't meet the requirements under the Code, but the labelling must be correct when it is sold in New Zealand. See the ['Packaging and labelling'](#) [orange] card.



The Code specifies the common food allergens you must know about. These are: peanuts, crustacea, molluscs, fish, milk, egg, gluten, wheat, soy, sesame, lupin, sulphites (when added at more than 10mg/kg), almonds, Brazil nuts, cashews, hazelnuts, macadamias, pecans, pine nuts, pistachios, walnuts.

Allergens to know about



Egg



Peanuts



Milk



Soy



Sesame



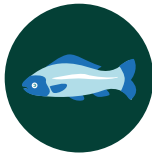
Lupin



Gluten
(barley, oats, rye, wheat)



Wheat



Fish



Crustacean



Molluscs



Sulphites



Almonds



Brazil nuts



Cashews



Hazelnuts



Macadamias



Pecans



Pine nuts



Pistachios



Walnuts

- More information on allergens can be found in the 'Allergen labelling - Knowing what's in your food and how to label it' document at www.mpi.govt.nz/dmsdocument/50725.



- Horticulture: Using the wrong horticultural fertilisers and chemicals (for example herbicides, pesticides and fungicides), or using them incorrectly (for example using too much or at the wrong time), can mean they end up in food at unacceptable levels. You should always check and follow instructions on the label and only harvest plants after the specified withholding period.



- Horticulture: You don't have to test your crops to prove they meet the limits, but random sampling and testing is carried out by MPI, and sometimes businesses you supply will also test your food. If your food doesn't meet the limits, you will have to show that you took all of the necessary steps to meet the limits.



- Horticulture: There are rules about the maximum amount of horticultural fertilisers and chemicals allowed in horticultural food on the MPI website: www.mpi.govt.nz/agriculture/agricultural-compounds-vet-medicines/maximum-residue-levels-agricultural-compounds/.



Rules you must follow

- Keep details of the ingredients you use (for example write down and follow your recipes) so you know what ingredients and allergens they contain.
- Check recipes or specifications meet the rules in the Code.
- Check the labels of your ingredients or the foods you use.
- You /your staff must know which of your foods contain allergens and how to prevent cross contamination with allergens. See the 'Preventing contamination of food and drink' [orange] card.
- Wheat flour sold as suitable for making bread must contain 2 to 3mg/kg of folic acid. For more details see Standard 2.1.1 of the Code www.legislation.gov.au/F2015L00420/latest/text.
- When you are making some types of food or drink (for example beer, butter, cheese, chocolate, wine) the Code states that there are only certain ingredients, food additives and processing aids you can (or must) use. There are also limits for these that you need to follow.
- Check that any processing aids, additives, and vitamins or minerals used in your recipes are permitted under the Code.
- If you are repacking food made by others, you must ensure it is correctly labelled.
- You must be able to tell customers whether a food contains each individual allergen if they ask. For packaged foods this information must be on the packaging.



D

Do



- Food service/retailer: Either the
 - ☐ day-to-day manager, or
 - ☐ delegated person's name and/or position _____ (tick who is responsible for the plan) must be able to explain to customers what allergens and other information required by the Code is in their food.



- Food service/retailer: You must check all of the ingredients in food, as well as sauces, garnishes served with, or added to food so you know which ones contain allergens.



- Food service/retailer: You/your staff must know which foods you serve contain any of the allergens listed in the Know section. You/your staff must be able to tell customers if your food contains any of the allergens, using the required allergen name, listed in the **Know** section.
- If you think a food isn't labelled correctly, especially if it has an allergen that isn't listed using its required allergen name (for example a frozen pie does not list wheat flour and gluten) – check with your supplier before selling it.



- Ask your supplier for information about unlabelled products or for translations if imported.



- Wine: If you're exporting you must only use approved food additives and ingredients and/or at the right stage for the market you're exporting to. Follow the '[Meeting Export Requirements \(wine only\)](#)' [orange] card.



- Horticulture: Ensure horticultural fertiliser and chemical residues in crops do not exceed maximum residue level requirements.

Things to show your verifier

- Your verifier will ask:
 - how you know what is in the ingredients you use,
 - how you know the recipes or specifications you use meet the requirements of the Code,
 - how you know which food additives and processing aids are safe to use in your food or drink, and how much you can use,
 - (bread) how you know bread flour you produce, pack or import contains the correct amount of folic acid.
- Your verifier may ask:
 - staff to tell them which foods contain allergens.
 - (horticulture) how you know which horticultural fertilisers and chemicals have been applied to crops, and how you know maximum residue levels are not exceeded.

